SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #84 · PRAYER

# “If I pray enough, I shouldn’t need a doctor or counselor.”

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## Where it often comes from

Teaching that seeking medical or psychological help shows weak faith. Stories of healing through prayer alone. Fear of what others at church would think. Distrust of doctors or counselors. Pride or embarrassment about needing help.

## What Scripture teaches

Prayer and practical help go together in Scripture. James tells the sick to call the elders to pray over them and anoint them with oil, which in that time was also used as medicine. The Good Samaritan bandaged wounds with oil and wine. Luke was a beloved physician. Jesus said the sick need a doctor. Praying and seeking care are not opposites; God often answers prayer through doctors and counselors.

> *“Is any one of you sick? He should call the elders of the church to pray over him and anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer offered in faith will restore the one who is sick. The Lord will raise him up. If he has sinned, he will be forgiven”* **(James 5:14–15)**.

## Also see

> “He went to him and bandaged his wounds, pouring on oil and wine. Then he put him on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him” **(Luke 10:34)**.

> “On hearing this, Jesus said, ‘It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.’” **(Matthew 9:12)**.

> “Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas send you greetings” **(Colossians 4:14)**.

> “Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed” **(Proverbs 15:22)**.

## Common self-statements

- If I pray enough, I won’t need help.
- Seeing a doctor means I don’t trust God.
- Counseling is for people with weak faith.
- God will be disappointed if I get treatment.
- My prayers should be enough.
- Taking medicine is giving up on God.

## Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you must choose between prayer and help.
- **Should statements:** “I should be able to pray this away.”
- **Discounting Scripture:** Overlooking examples of prayer and care together.
- **Double standard:** Accepting help for some problems but not others.

## Challenging questions

- What did James tell the sick to do besides pray?
- How did the Good Samaritan care for the wounded man?
- What did Jesus say about who needs a doctor?
- Could God answer my prayers through a doctor or counselor?
- Would I tell a friend with a broken bone to only pray?
- Is my hesitation about faith, or about fear or pride?
- What help might God be offering me right now?

## Truth summary

> Praying and getting help are not opposites. God often answers prayer through doctors, counselors, and medicine. I can pray with faith and also seek wise care. Seeking help is good stewardship of the life God gave me, not a lack of faith.

## Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Sickness
- Therapy
- Prayer, Answers to
- Help
- Wisdom

## Listen: Overcoming Depression

**Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

*Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"*

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# My Plan for Replacing "If I pray enough, I shouldn't need a doctor or counselor"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

**Name:** _____ **Date started:** _____

## 1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

*Rate it now so you can see your progress later.*

**"If I pray enough, I shouldn't need a doctor or counselor."** I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

## 2 My best question

*The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.*

- ☐ What did James say besides pray?
- ☐ How did the Good Samaritan help?
- ☐ Who needs a doctor, according to Jesus?
- ☐ Could God answer through a doctor?
- ☐ Would I tell a friend to only pray?
- ☐ What help is God offering me now?

**My own question:** _____

## 3 My replacement truth

*The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.*

- ☐ Prayer and practical help go together.
- ☐ God often answers prayer through doctors and counselors.
- ☐ Seeking help is good stewardship.
- ☐ I can pray with faith and get care.
- ☐ The sick need a doctor, and that is no shame.
- ☐ With many advisers, plans succeed.

**In my own words:** _____

## 4 My Scripture

*The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.*

- [ ] **James 5:14–15**
  *"Is any one of you sick? He should call the elders of the church to pray over him and anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord. And the prayer offered in faith will restore the one who is sick. The Lord will raise him up. If he has sinned, he will be forgiven."*
- [ ] **Luke 10:34**
  *"He went to him and bandaged his wounds, pouring on oil and wine. Then he put him on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him."*
- [ ] **Matthew 9:12**
  *"On hearing this, Jesus said, 'It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick.'"*
- [ ] **Colossians 4:14**
  *"Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas send you greetings."*
- [ ] **Proverbs 15:22**
  *"Plans fail for lack of counsel, but with many advisers they succeed."*

**A verse I found myself:** _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

# Practicing the Truth

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## 5 My practice plan

*Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.*

### EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

### PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Prayer and care log:** Each day, write one prayer for my health and one practical step I took to care for it.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, James 5:15 becomes: "And the prayer offered in faith will restore **Sarah** when **she** is sick. The Lord will raise **her** up."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Sickness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

## 6 My action step this week

*Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.*

- ☐ **Pray about your health,** then make one appointment you've been putting off.
- ☐ **Ask your church elders or a pastor to pray for you,** and tell them about any treatment you're receiving.
- ☐ **Read Luke 10:30–37,** and write how the Samaritan combined compassion and care.
- ☐ **Write your fears about getting help,** and answer each with a truth from this card.

**What I will do:** _____

**When:** _____

**What the lie predicts will happen:** _____

## 7 End-of-week check-in

*Bring this page to your next session.*

**What actually happened:** _____

What I learned: _____

**The lie** "If I pray enough, I shouldn't need a doctor or counselor": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

## Daily practice tracker

| Day | Read my card | Said my verse | Used my reminder | One prayer and one step of care |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | | | | |
| Tue | | | | |
| Wed | | | | |
| Thu | | | | |
| Fri | | | | |
| Sat | | | | |
| Sun | | | | |

## My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I pray enough, I shouldn't need a doctor or counselor.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

*Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.*

## Prayer

*Father, thank You that You hear my prayers and that You often answer through people You have gifted to heal. Help me reject the lie that if I pray enough, I shouldn't need a doctor or counselor. Give me humility to seek help and faith to trust You through it. In Jesus' name, Amen.*

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*Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.*